

into two sections—Appearance and Notification Area, with a few “enable/disable” options. You can lock, hide or keep the taskbar over other applications by checking their respective options. Choosing ‘Show Quick Launch’ will add a Quick Launch panel in the taskbar just next to the Start button. This is used to start the most frequently-used applications, such as Winamp, without having to go through the list of applications in the Start Menu. You can also choose to disable the clock.



The Taskbar and Start Menu Properties dialog box

XP displays icons for active and urgent notifications in the System Tray. For instance, there will be a Messenger icon in the System Tray as long as it is actively running. Now if many such applications are running, then the System Tray would occupy a fourth of the taskbar! To prevent this, XP has a “hide” button to hide all inactive icons. This way, you see only those applications that are currently active.

You can customise the Start Menu settings if you think the current settings don’t suit you. The Start Menu tab gives you two options to work with—‘Start Menu’ and ‘Classic Start Menu’. The latter is a style that is common to earlier versions of Windows such as Windows 2000 and 98. Once you have chosen between these two, you can click on the ‘Customise’ button to make finer changes such as the size of the icons and the list of programs.

Another useful option in the Taskbar is to add Toolbars. A Toolbar is something similar to Quick Launch—it gives faster access to items. (The first option in the pop-up that comes on right clicking the taskbar is for adding Toolbars.) You can choose to add toolbars for Links, Desktop (to access icons on the desktop), and more. You can also create your own toolbar. Let’s say you want to create a toolbar for the ‘My Documents’ folder. Choose ‘New toolbar...’ and then select ‘My Documents’ from the list that comes up.